

|By Shaifali Sandhya|

It first happened 20 years ago. On Saturday, March 17, 1989, no sooner did the clock strike 10 p.m., Avanti pretended that she was deep in slumber. "I'm 55 years old but I've never been aroused," says Avanti, a middle-class homemaker, "I haven't had sex in 20 years." She adds, "He wanted to have sex in front of mirrors. He wanted me to watch porn," Avanti recalls. "When sex happened," she adds, "it was rough." She solved the issue by feigning sleep. Not daunted, her husband would wake her up and coerce her to their bedroom. "There was no gentleness. There was no softness. I used to feel pain." There were no magazines at that time that wrote about sex, so Avanti had no way of knowing what she ought to be feeling, leave alone whether what she was feeling was right. But one day she decided on her own, "I just said, 'Just leave me alone. I can't do this'. So we stopped. Last month he wanted it but I pushed him away."

Avanti is one of many wives uninterested in sex; Avanti's husband, Ramesh, had some inkling, "She used to reject me," but he told himself, "Why should I do it for my own enjoyment?" Whether he said or she said that they were the one to put a full stop to sex, their marriage is one of many where sex is on a standstill or spilling over with partners outside of marriage. Yet, urban India, we are told, is swinging with sexually bursting bosoms, bawdy toys, kinky bondage, plunging cleavage, all media images that interfere with the sexual habits of Indian couples.

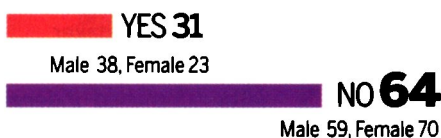
When a larger-than-life view of sex in India interferes with the sexual habits of husbands and wives, it enhances people's private preoccupations; its yawning gulf from reality dampens the success of marriage. Why do we imagine the improbable? What are the risqué mental leaps husbands and wives make? And, what does mental *masti*, forays in the labyrinths of our mind, tell us about the modern marriage?

As Avanti's story shows, a nation's imagination of sex is different from its actuality. Within marriages, when I interviewed both the husband and wife inhabiting one marriage, my research, based on 400 interviews of Indian husbands and wives between 1997 and 2009, concluded that even while a majority (64 per cent) of husbands and wives deemed sexual pleasure necessary for marriage, it was elusive. There are other such indicators of sexual unhappiness: one-third of the couples interviewed were uninterested in sex; only 16 per cent of wives reported orgasms, the biological indicator of female satisfaction, on multiple occasions; 4 per cent refrained from sex, choosing to be asexual for weeks, months, and sometimes for decades; while 24-44 per cent reported being dissatisfied with how much they were getting, alongside widespread poor female sexual health (pain during intercourse and uterine tract infections). While many

81

PER CENT OF WOMEN COMPARED TO 68 PER CENT OF MEN REPORTED THAT THEIR PARTNERS WERE COMFORTABLE ABOUT LISTENING TO THEIR FANTASIES.

Have you ever shared your sexual fantasies with your partner?



Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

More than two in five people in Ludhiana have shared their fantasies with their partners, the highest for any city. Fifty-five per cent men and 32 per cent women in the city admitted to it.

Has your partner ever shared his/her sexual fantasies with you?



Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

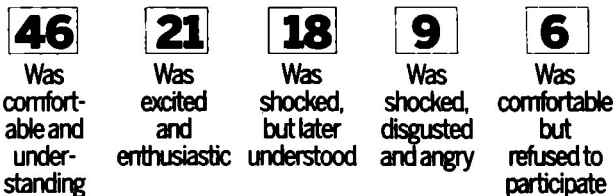
Have you ever tried your partner's fantasy?



For 1,725 respondents of the total 5,371 whose partners have shared their sexual fantasies. Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

ACTION REACTION

Most asserted that their partners were quite understanding when they revealed their fantasies to them. Clearly, honesty is the best sexuality.



For 1,642 respondents of the total 5,371 who have shared their sexual fantasies with their partners. All figures in per cent.